

Motherboards, or Mainboards as they are referred to, are the foundation on which your computer system is built, and enable you to connect various external devices to it. Its sheer indispensability calls for better understanding this component, so that you can make a wise decision before buying one. If you're an enthusiast, you may want a motherboard that you can push to the limits; if you only want something that's steady and reliable for everyday tasks, you need to first realise what those tasks are, and buy accordingly.

The year 2003 was quite fruitful in terms of the number of technologies making it to the desktop level. The introduction of new flagship chipsets from Intel—the 865 and the 875P—for their newer 800 FSB processors, and the percolation of dual-channel memory support for mainstream desktop boards, pushed the performance envelope even further.

For the AMD platform, you have the KT600 chipset from VIA, which increased the chipset line-up for AMD processors. nVidia's nForce2 chipset, holds its fort as the best AMD platform. And finally, the introduction of 64-bit computing from AMD. With so much happening in such a short span of time, choosing the right board has become all the more difficult.

So, we thought it about time to test the range of motherboards available to Indian assemblers. We decided against a comparison of AMD's Athlon 64-bit motherboards, simply because of the lack of availability of the required registered memories, and the immaturity of this platform in the Indian perspective. We decided to round up these boards in the not-too-far-away future, as and when it's a little more feasible.

Like every other piece of hardware, motherboards are also bringing down their prices. The low-end segment, which was once dominated by the likes of Mercury and HiS, has been the one to most

reflect the price drop. In India, this is a segment with great volumes of sales, which has attracted big players in the form of ASUS, Gigabyte and MSI—albeit at slightly higher prices. Even Intel couldn't resist, and now there are original Intel motherboards available at the lower-end of the motherboard see-saw. The cheapest motherboard we got was priced at a relief-giving Rs 2,350, meaning a sub-Rs 22,000 Pentium 4 system, can safely be called yours.

Though the mid-range segment in this test will lighten your pockets by Rs 7,000 or Rs 8,000, you are the proud owner of a board that has a plethora of features—especially those based on the nForce chipset. The high-end boards still cost above Rs 10,000, but contribute immensely to building your dream PC, that will give you immense boasting-minutes until the next upgrade is forced upon you. Apart from the 49 motherboards that we tested, we also featured three not-so-run-of-the-mill motherboards for their sheer uniqueness. Strap up for the ride.

